but he swallowed the rest of the bait, and signed a Persian document putting his consent in writing. According to Mohan Lal, ‘The offer was not received by the Envoy altogether without suspicion; but as he has no hope of military aid, and considered the idea of a retreat disgraceful to the British name, he was like a drowning man catching at straws.’[119]

For Akbar Khan, this was the final evidence he needed of the duplicity of the Envoy. He showed the document to Aminullah Khan and warned the other chiefs of Macnaghten’s willingness to betray his agreements with them and do a secret deal behind their backs. Then he sent a message to Macnaghten to meet him again the following morning to finalise details of the plot. Macnaghten agreed.

George Lawrence, Mackenzie and Trevor were summoned by the Envoy at dawn and told about the offer. According to Lawrence, Macnaghten said:

> that he had every reasonable hope it would bring our present difficulties to an early and happy termination, and that Akbar was to give up Aminoollah Khan as a prisoner to us. Sir William then warned me to be ready to gallop to the King with the intelligence and to acquaint him with Akbar’s proposal. On me again remarking that the scheme seemed a dangerous one and asking if he did not apprehend any treachery, he replied, ‘Dangerous it is, but if it succeeds it is worth all risks. The Rebels have not fulfilled even one Article of the Treaty and I have no confidence in them, and if by it we can only save our Honour, all will be well. At any rate I would sooner suffer a hundred deaths than live the last six weeks over again.’

At this point, Hasan Khan, the head of Mackenzie’s jezailchis who had faithfully led the retreat from the commissariat fort, intervened and ‘repeatedly warned Sir William of the likelihood of a fatal termination to his hazardous interviews with the Afghan chiefs. He argued that surely he was the better judge of the intentions of his own countrymen than Sir William could be, and that among them no dishonour was attached to what we call treachery.’ Mackenzie also pointed out that the offer sounded very suspicious, but Macnaghten replied: ‘A plot! Let me alone for that – trust me for that!’ To Elphinstone, who also raised the same objection, Macnaghten replied smugly: ‘Leave it to me. I understand these things better than you.’

Shelton was supposed to send a military escort with Macnaghten, but the cavalry, disorganised as ever, were not ready to leave. After a short wait, the impatient Macnaghten decided to head off for his appointment with just his small personal guard, accompanied by his three assistants, Lawrence, Trevor and Mackenzie. Akbar Khan was already waiting at the agreed